VE Day & The End of War in Europe

Key Enquiry Question: Why did millions celebrate with street parties on 8 May 1945, and what challenges lay ahead?

LESSON 10
KEY STAGE 2



Source A: *A vast crowd of celebrating citizens fills Trafalgar Square beneath Nelson's Column on 8 May 1945. (Imperial War Museum)*

HISTORICAL READING • WHAT THIS TELLS US

On Tuesday 8 May 1945, Prime Minister Winston Churchill announced that Nazi Germany had surrendered. After **five years, eight months, and four days** of air raids, blackout, and separation, the war in Europe was finally over.

Across Britain, communities dragged tables into the middle of bomb-damaged streets, decorated houses with Union flags, and shared precious saved ration sweets so children could celebrate peace.

Task 1: Artifact Detective • The Bomb-Damaged Street Party

PRIMARY EVIDENCE



Source B: *Two young girls wave Union flags amidst the bomb rubble and ruined brickwork of Battersea, London, on VE Day, 8 May 1945. (Imperial War Museum HU 49414)*

1. Look closely at Source B. Notice the rubble and ruined brickwork behind the children. What does this contrast between destruction and celebration tell us about civilian resilience?

2. Families saved sugar, margarine, and jam coupons for months to bake treats for this single afternoon. Why was giving children a street party so important to British mothers?

Task 2: Active Chronological Challenge • 8 May 1945: The Day Peace Arrived

CHRONOLOGICAL UNDERSTANDING

STAGE 1 • 3:00 PM

Churchill's Broadcast

Crowds gather around wireless sets in silence to hear Churchill proclaim: "The German war is at an end!"

What emotions would sweep through a family hearing the prime minister utter those words?

STAGE 2 • 6:00 PM

The Street Party Feasts

Tables dragged onto pavements. Pianos wheeled out. Neighbours sing wartime songs and dance the conga.

Why did neighbours who had sheltered together through the Blitz share such unbreakable bonds?

STAGE 3 • 10:00 PM

Floodlights and Bonfires

Blackout ended. For the first time in six years, bright floodlights illuminate St Paul's Cathedral and Big Ben.

Why was switching on the lights across Britain the most powerful symbol of victory?

Task 3: Visual Investigation • Design a VE Day Street Party Table & Community Feast

TACTILE INVESTIGATION

Draw your community street party layout with Union Jack bunting, celebration tables, sandwiches, and treats.

1. The Pooled Ration Sweet Feast
How did children sharing saved chocolate and homemade jam tarts create a festive celebration?

2. The Empty Chairs of Remembrance
Why did many mothers and soldiers feel quiet tears of sorrow amidst the cheering crowds?

3. Continuing Post-War Rationing
Why did food and clothing rationing have to continue for years after 1945 across Britain?

4. Rebuilding Bomb-Damaged Britain
With 1 in 3 homes damaged, how did Britain begin building new prefabricated houses and schools?

Task 4: "Thinking Heads" • Contrasting Historical Perspectives

CONTRASTING PERSPECTIVES

1 10-Year-Old London Child at the Party

You have lived almost your entire memory in blackout, sirens, and fear. How does it feel to see the street bathed in bright light and laughter?

2 Returning Soldier Surveying His Street

What mixed feelings of profound joy and quiet sorrow do you feel looking at your bomb-damaged neighbourhood and missing friends?

Task 5: Mission Challenge • Lessons for Tomorrow

HISTORIAN CHALLENGE

Big Question: Why is it vital that we continue to remember the sacrifices, courage, and lessons of the Second World War generation today?